

STAGE TWO • PROFESSIONAL IDENTITY & PERSONAL BRAND

FIRSTS

FACILITATOR NOTES / SCRIPT

Suggested language for openings, transitions, and prompting discussion

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

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FIRSTS • Facilitator Notes / Script

Stage Two • Professional Identity & Personal Brand

HOW TO USE THIS SCRIPT

This document is written for a first-time or less confident facilitator who wants actual suggested language, not just a topic list. Everything in quotes is meant to be read close to verbatim, or adapted lightly into your own voice.

Stage Two involves more genuinely vulnerable moments than Stage One — recording yourself on video, getting honest reputation feedback, auditing your own digital footprint. This script leans especially heavily on Parts 3 and 4 as a result; expect to use this document more actively in this stage than in Stage One.

It's organized into four parts: session openings, transitions between FIRSTS, discussion prompting for five specific situations that come up often in this stage, and tricky moments flagged at specific FIRSTS where participants commonly get uncomfortable or stuck.

Part 1 — Session Openings

Opening Session 1

"Welcome to Stage Two. Last stage was about understanding who you are — your values, your strengths, your vision. This stage is about how that translates into how other people actually experience you: your introduction, your pitch, your brand statement, how you write, how you carry yourself."

"A lot of what we do today involves saying things out loud, sometimes to a partner, sometimes recording yourself on your own phone. That's genuinely uncomfortable for most people, myself included the first time I did this kind of work. The discomfort is normal and it's part of how this actually improves."

Opening Session 2

"Last time was about the words you use to describe yourself. Today is about strategy — being deliberate about the reputation you're building instead of letting it form by accident."

"One heads-up: FIRST B9 asks you to get honest reputation feedback from someone you trust. We'll set that up today, but the actual conversation happens on your own time before we reconvene. I'll check in on how it went next time."

Opening Session 3

"This is our longest, most hands-on session in the whole program. We're not just planning today — we're actually editing your LinkedIn profile, building a website, and taking real headshot photos. Have your laptop, phone, and LinkedIn login ready."

"If at any point this session runs long, know that we can pick up wherever we leave off next time — the content doesn't lose anything by being split across two sittings if we need to."

Opening Session 4

"Today we shift from static profiles and materials to how you communicate live — in email, in meetings, in conversation, and on camera. Two of today's exercises involve recording yourself again, so have your phone ready."

Opening Session 5

"Today is about visibility — not just having a strong profile, but actually showing up in your professional community. This ranges from something as small as a thoughtful comment to something as ambitious as your own blog post."

"I want to be upfront: not everyone needs to become a content creator. The goal is finding your own sustainable version of visibility, not performing a version that doesn't fit you."

Opening Session 6 (Stage Close)

"This is our final session for Stage Two, and it's where everything becomes tangible: your resume, your cover letter, your contact materials, and a real, spoken walkthrough of your best work."

"Bring your current resume and a real job posting you're genuinely interested in — we're going to work with real materials today, not hypothetical ones."

Part 2 — Transitions Between FIRSTS

A few sentences said out loud between exercises and between sessions turns a checklist into a coherent narrative.

FIRST B1 → B2

"You've got a solid introduction for meeting someone new. The elevator pitch is a related but distinct skill — it's built for when you have even less time and need to land a specific point."

FIRST B3 → B4

"You now have one sentence that captures your brand. Let's zoom out from that single sentence to how you communicate more broadly, starting with something you do constantly: email."

Session 1 → Session 2

"Today was about finding the right words. Next session is about strategy — being deliberate about the reputation those words build over time, not just the moment they're spoken."

FIRST B9 → B10

"Reputation is often invisible until someone tells you. Image is the opposite — it's the most visible, immediate signal people pick up on, often before you say a word."

Session 2 → Session 3

"Everything so far has been about who you are and how people perceive you in person. Today, we build the actual digital presence — profile, website, portfolio — that carries that identity when you're not in the room."

FIRST B16 → B17

"Now that you know what's already out there about you, let's build something you actually control — a personal website that says what you want it to say."

Session 3 → Session 4

"Your profiles and materials are built. Now let's talk about the live, moment-to-moment communication that happens on top of all that — email, meetings, conversation."

FIRST B25 → B26

"We just practiced listening to someone else. Now let's turn the camera on you — recording yourself is its own kind of listening, to how you actually come across."

Session 4 → Session 5

"You can now communicate clearly one-on-one and on camera. Session 5 scales that up: how do you show up, visibly, to a broader professional audience?"

FIRST B31 → B32

"You've outlined one post. A thought leadership series asks: what if this wasn't a one-time thing, but a sustained, recognizable body of work?"

Session 5 → Session 6

"You've built visibility and a real voice. This final session turns everything from this entire stage into concrete, finished materials: resume, cover letter, contact info, and a real portfolio walkthrough."

Part 3 — Prompting Discussion in the Moment

Five situations that come up often in this specific stage, with suggested language for each.

Someone is visibly uncomfortable recording themselves (B26, B27)

“This is genuinely one of the most uncomfortable parts of the whole program for most people. You don't have to share the recording with anyone — the value is entirely in watching it yourself.”

A participant's brand statement or pitch sounds generic after multiple attempts

“Let's get specific. Tell me about one real project or moment — not the general idea, the actual thing that happened.” (Concrete stories almost always surface a sharper statement than abstract brainstorming.)

Someone resists the LinkedIn or digital footprint work (“I don't really use social media”)

“That's completely fair, and you don't have to become active on it. But a recruiter will likely still look, so this is about making sure what exists says what you'd want it to — not about becoming a power user.”

A participant gets defensive after a peer's honest reputation feedback (B9)

“It's genuinely hard to hear something you didn't expect about yourself. Take a breath — you don't have to agree with it, but sitting with it for a moment before reacting usually reveals something useful.”

The room is reluctant to give real feedback during a peer review activity

“Vague, kind feedback doesn't actually help anyone here. Try this frame: one specific thing that worked, one specific thing you'd change. That's it — it's not a performance review, just two honest observations.”

Part 4 — Tricky Moments by FIRST

Four specific *FIRSTS* (one of them a full section) where participants commonly get stuck, defensive, or uncomfortable — and language to navigate each moment.

FIRST B9

Professional Reputation Awareness

FACILITATOR NOTE

This can genuinely sting if the honest feedback doesn't match self-perception. Normalize the gap explicitly: most people carry some version of this mismatch, and noticing it is the entire point of the exercise, not a personal failing.

FIRST B16

Digital Footprint Audit

FACILITATOR NOTE

Some participants will find genuinely concerning content from their past (old posts, tagged photos, a negative review, a past legal or academic issue). Have a private, individual conversation ready rather than addressing anything specific in front of the group.

FIRST B19

Professional Headshot

FACILITATOR NOTE

Body image and appearance anxiety can surface here more than facilitators expect. Keep the framing squarely on professional norms (lighting, background, expression) rather than personal appearance, and never comment on how someone looks beyond those specific, neutral factors.

FIRST B28-B34

Professional Visibility (full section)

FACILITATOR NOTE

Some participants will feel genuine anxiety about “putting themselves out there” publicly online. Explicitly validate that visibility exists on a spectrum — a single thoughtful comment counts as real participation, not just publishing original articles.